

The Last Round

written by

Bugashane Mugoovi

(317) 827-5137
Smugoovi@gmail.com

INT. ROOM

The room is silent; people in suits fill every corner. And in front, a man is at the table, looking at the people with their heads down.

BANG!

THE MAN

Such a shame. And so close as well.
But we move on.

The Man claps his hands; the four people at the table snap back. But faces are still down; one is shaking, looking like they're about to scream, and the other three have their eyes open, faces shaking.

THE MAN (CONT'D)

Don't worry, you four have made it.
Just one last game.

The Man smiles, looking at the four at the table.

THE MAN (CONT'D)

This round is simple. It's all
about you four. And as always,
there are "no" wrong "answers."

The Man looks at the one closest to breaking.

THE MAN (CONT'D)

You guys should be happy, the
game's almost over, and you'll
never have to see us again.

No movement. All still face down, shaking, massaging their fingers. The Man says nothing.

THE MAN (CONT'D)

Here is your next and final game.
It's simple. All you have to do is
prove that what you did in this
game was morally correct, or you
can choose to go in the opposite
direction of why this game and what
it stands for is morally wrong.

They all look up at each other; an uncertain feeling etched on their faces. Then they look to the Man.

THE MAN (CONT'D)

The rule of the game hasn't
changed, so keep that in mind.

(MORE)

THE MAN (CONT'D)

Now then, who's brave enough to go first?

They look at each other. Then one of them begins to talk.

DANI

Say it.

While looking over at Maddie.

MADDIE

Say what.

DANI

Whatever's been sitting behind your teeth since the last game.

MADDIE

You killing Jane?

DANI

There it is. I'll say it for you.

I killed her. I'm not dressing that up as anything. And if it came down to it i would do it again, I'd do the same thing to any of you.

Call it murder if you want. Call it whatever makes you sleep at night. But murder needs a choice, and I didn't have one, that wasn't a gun to my head, none of us built this fucking game. We got thrown into it. Whatever's wrong with this game belongs only to The Man. Not me, the one forced to play it.

And none of you are clean either. You made the exact same call I did to get here. That means somewhere back there, you chose yourself too. We're not four different kinds of people in this room. No, we're four people who did what needed to be done to survive.

Dani looks around then focuses at Maddie

DANI (CONT'D)

Now you tell me, Should I have laid down and let her win?

Maddie looks away

MADDIE

...

DANI

Like i though. Virtue died the second I got thrown into this thing. I'm not going to lose pretend I have integrity. A dead person doesn't get credit for her ethics; they are dead.

And let me tell you, everything keeps moving forward. And as for her she was a cog in the machine, and as you can see nothing changes. We're still in here.

But to be honest, I do feel guilty. I'll feel it the rest of my life, wherever that ends up being. That's not proof I did something wrong. It's proof I was still a person when I did it.

So yeah. I value my life over any of yours. Any time. Any day.

Maddie looks at Dani. Anger in her eyes.

MADDIE

Oh, okay, I see. So you want to talk about the game? Fine. Let's talk about the fucking game.

Maddie's voice start to rise

MADDIE (CONT'D)

Remember that girl from two rounds ago? She was four feet away from you. The round was already over. Over, Dani. She wasn't fighting you. She was on the ground, asking, not fighting, asking, to be brought over the line.

There was no threat to your life. Just a hand. One hand stretched out across four feet of floor. That was it. That was the whole distance between that girl living and dying.

(MORE)

MADDIE (CONT'D)

But you didn't reach out. You chose the man in the black suit. And half a minute later, they shot her dead.

That's not you being forced. That's you deciding her life stopped mattering the second it stopped being a threat to you.

DANI

(flat, not defensive –
just factual)

Because I knew... If I let her live, it would come back and bite me later.

MADDIE

Yeah, right. I saw the look on your face when she got shot—nothing. So don't you dare stand there and act like guilt makes you a person.

(stepping closer, voice
rising)

I also killed someone in this game!
I don't decorate it. It was wrong.
It's still *fucking* wrong.

Maddie takes a big breath in and looks down

MADDIE (CONT'D)

Guilt isn't a badge, Dani, it's the minimum interest you pay on something monstrous, and you're spending it like currency.

This whole thing is rotten from the top down. And the fact that we can stand here calmly arguing over whose version of "I had no choice" sounds more noble, that tells you exactly how well it worked on us.

Rey chuckles

REY

You're both still at each other's throat for something that was never going to give either of you a fair deal.

But look at me I don't need validation.

(MORE)

REY (CONT'D)

I didn't drag anyone over a finish line, and I didn't wait for a buzzer to decide what I was willing to do to survive. I'm not about to play sick over my choices just to make you two feel better about yours.

Maddie, you keep saying "wrong."
Wrong compared to what, exactly?

Rey looks around at everyone

Morality's a luxury, Maddie. none of us could afford it in here, not in this round, not any round before. You know that. WE ALL KNOW THAT. But I just stopped pretending I care.

And Dani, as you said. I value my life more than anyone's. So I'm not asking either of you for forgiveness. I'm just here to finish this and get the hell out.

REY looks at NORA

REY (CONT'D)

You've been awfully quiet over there. You got something to add, or you just gonna stand there?

NORA

Let me get this straight Maddie wants forgiveness for being human. Dani wants to be right for still having a conscience. And Rey, you just want credit for being honest enough to admit you don't have one.

None of you are wrong. None of you invented this. You walked in already holding it.

DANI

Special my ass. Look who's talking. The girl that doesn't even know herself.

NORA

(barely a beat,
unbothered)
(MORE)

NORA (CONT'D)

You're just walking the same circle
this whole game wanted you walking
from the start. That's just the
part none of you want to hear.

I know how this sounds. Saying this
right now. But there's this book –

REY

(muttered)

Not this again.

NORA (CONT'D)

On the Genealogy of Morals. The
author goes digging for where words
like "good" and "evil" actually
came from. Funny thing is, "good"
used to just mean strong. Winning.
It's the ones who lost who came up
with "evil" a word for whoever beat
them. And then they built
themselves a brand new "good" to
hide behind instead.

MADDIE

What are you getting at?

NORA

Let me dumb it down for you, since
you're having a hard time
understanding – they hid behind it
because it made them humble.
Patient. Weak. He calls it
ressentiment. A psychological
coping mechanism dressed up as a
virtue.

(NORA points a finger at them)

See, Dani kills out of fear, then
calls it 'human instinct' to feel
noble. Maddie plays the victim,
using her guilt as a luxury badge
to look pure. And Rey? Rey claims
she's 'honest,' but she's just
terrified that if she stops moving,
the weight of what she's done will
crush her. You've all invented a
bunch of fragile little rules to
make yourselves feel like masters.

MADDIE

You should stop.

REY

...

NORA

(talking straight over
her)

But you aren't masters. There's no
fucking difference between any of
you. You're all just—

LOUD BANG.

A gunshot cuts her off mid-sentence. NORA drops face-first
onto the table.

Silence. Maddie, Dani, and Rey flinch slightly, then turn
toward the head of the table—where THE MAN is still standing
exactly where he's been the whole time.

THE MAN

Remember. There's only one rule.

THE MAN (CONT'D)

Continue.

He doesn't move again. He doesn't need to.

REY

(smiles a bit)

She knew the rule. And she broke it
anyway.

DANI

Three left. I like those odds.

MADDIE

Jesus Christ. She's not even cold
yet, Dani.

DANI

I'm not saying I wanted it. I'm
saying it's true.

REY

Nobody made her say it. It was her
own choice. And you know what's
funny?

Rey lets out a short, humorless laugh, still staring at the
floor. Slowly, she starts grinning.

REY (CONT'D)

She hands us this whole speech about good and evil, how "good" used to just mean strong and winning, and then she goes and proves her own point for us, seconds later, face down on the table.

Actually, she brought up a very good point. I am not evil for what I did in this game. I didn't lose. If I'd lost, sure, call me evil; I would definitely deserve it.

But I'm still here. So, by Nora's own dead philosopher's logic, that makes me good. Strong, actually. The people who lose are the ones who need a word like "evil" they need somebody to blame for losing. But I haven't lost. So I don't need the word.

MADDIE

(disgusted, closing the distance)

It's been thirty seconds, and you're already picking apart her argument to justify your own shit.

REY

I'm using it because it's true. Not because it's convenient.

Rey stands, finally, brushing herself off.

REY (CONT'D)

You want to know if I feel anything? Fine, yeah. Somewhere in here, I'm angry. None of us are used to watching people die like this, no matter how many rounds we've survived.

But we all had the same choice the second we were forced in here: either get used to what's happening around you, or stay the exact same person you were outside in here and die still being that person. I didn't do the second one. Neither were either of you, or you wouldn't be standing here.

(MORE)

REY (CONT'D)

There's a reason the three of us made it this far and Jane and NORA didn't. We saw what happens when you don't follow the one rule they gave us. Break it, and end up like her. This is the last round. I'm not throwing it away for a debate.

So, was the game right? Were my choices in it right? To me, yeah. They were. I wouldn't be standing here if they weren't. Would they come back and bite me later? Probably. I still wouldn't undo a single one.

Maddie stands up and looks at Rey

MADDIE

So all of it's justified. The killing. Pushing people off ledges. Whatever else happened in there. Just because you're still breathing. Don't you see anything wrong with that?

REY

No, because we aren't murderers. Not before this, at least. We got thrown in here, and then we became one. That's not the same as choosing it.

MADDIE

What about the outside world? If they pull us out of here... would they call what you did justified? Same question for you, Dani. Would anyone out there call it survival? Or would they just call it what it looks like?

DANI

(flat, immediate)

Yes. I believe that. What I did, I did to survive. I'm not going to stand here and pretend otherwise.

REY

And I don't need the outside world's permission either. They're not in here.

(MORE)

REY (CONT'D)

They don't get a vote on my life
just because they're comfortable
enough to have opinions about it. I
trust myself. That's the whole
ballot.

MADDIE

Morality's not just some personal
little conviction, Rey. It's
something people agree on together.
That's the whole point of the word.

REY

(slow, humorless smile)
Oh, you want to go there. Okay.

If it's really just something
society agrees on together, walk me
through the people you killed,
Maddie. Run it by that same
society. Tell me exactly how they
vote on that one.

Maddie doesn't answer.

Dani has been quiet through all of it, watching the two of
them go back and forth. When Dani finally speaks, it's steady
—no crack in it.

DANI

Look at them. They broke the rule
already, and you're just going to
let them?

(Dani stands up, pointing
at the table)

There were five of us. Now there's
only three. They stopped playing
the second they started screaming
at each other. This is my round.
This is my win. Open the door and
let me get—

Then a gunshot. Dani drops.

Maddie and Rey don't flinch. Two deaths in, and there's
nothing left in either of them that jumps anymore.

The Man steps out from the head of the table. Unhurried. He
walks the length of the room until he's closer than he's been
all night — and turns, not to either of them, but straight to
camera.

THE MAN

(to camera)

Remember, there is only one rule.

(he lets it sit)

A small smile. He turns back toward the front of the room.

Two gunshots, back to back, off-screen